A STORY IN FIVE SHORT SCENES

Loving People Well

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The Phone at Dinner

In early spring, on a cool Thursday evening, Daniel sat across the kitchen table from Nora. The shop had lost its primary commercial client that morning, and the bank had sent a formal inquiry regarding the equipment loan.

As Daniel began to speak, his voice tight and slow, the screen on Nora's phone lit up beside her salad plate: three message alerts from the school committee.

Nora looked at the glowing glass. Then she looked across the table at Daniel's furrowed brow and tired eyes.

She reached out her hand, took the phone, walked into the hallway, and set it face down on the high shelf by the coat rack. She returned to the table and sat down.

"Tell me about the shop, Daniel," she said, leaning forward. "Tell me what you are afraid of."

She waited out the silence the way you wait for a deep well to answer a dropped stone.[1] The fear was the shop floor itself; his father had built it with his own hands, and Daniel could not bear to be the one who lost it. She learned his week, his worries, and his secret fears because she was interested in him, setting aside any desire for an audience.[2]

Remove the distractions.[3] Aim your attention at the person in the room with joy. That is the plain act of being present.

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[1] Proverbs 20:5

[2] Proverbs 27:23

[3] Luke 10:40-42

The Long Saturday

In late June, there came a Saturday with zero agenda. The river ran green and clear over the limestone weir. Nora walked down to the machine shop, carrying a deck of cards and a basket of early blackberries.

They sat on wooden crates beneath the weeping willow by the canal. They played cards badly. They laughed until Mrs. Gable's boys whistled from the road. Daniel told stories of his grandfather's first steam tractor; Nora told of an embarrassing music recital in her youth that she had kept hidden for years.

"A cheerful heart is good medicine,"[4] Nora said, quoting her grandmother.

For years, Daniel had believed love was relentless labor. Rest, he discovered, was an essential part of the work.[5] Love requires hours, space, and play. Some weeks call for company; some weeks call for leaving the door open and walking quietly beside someone.[6] You match the other person's cadence in pace and in distance.

[4] Proverbs 17:22

[5] Matthew 11:28; Mark 6:31

[6] Ecclesiastes 3:7

Tuesday's Word on Friday

On an afternoon in August, Daniel stood in Nora's garden, leaning against a weathered cedar post. Between sentences about the weather, his voice had dropped: Maddie's third orthopedic surgery was scheduled for Friday morning, and the surgeon was uncertain about the bone graft.

Nora had almost missed it. In past years, she would have nodded politely and forgotten the date by Thursday afternoon. Forgetting, she had learned, was a quiet abandonment.

After Daniel left the garden, she sat on the porch steps and spoke an audio memo into her phone. She noted the surgeon's name, the hospital wing, and the hour of the operation. On Thursday evening, a quiet chime reminded her.

On Friday afternoon at two o'clock, Nora walked into the hospital waiting room carrying two thermoses of warm beef stew and a small tin of butter cookies. Daniel sat alone in the corner chair, his coat rumpled and his face pale with worry.

"How is Maddie's surgery going, Daniel?" she asked quietly.

Daniel looked up, his fork freezing in the air, his eyes widening. "You remembered," he whispered, his voice catching in his throat.

Being remembered is a small way of being held in God's love.[7] Attention with memory makes a person known.

[7] Isaiah 49:16; Philippians 1:3

Seventy Times

In October, when the valley turned gold and red, Daniel had snapped at Nora over a delayed shipment, and later that month he missed her birthday supper while repairing a broken boiler at the mill. Nora caught herself opening a small notebook in her apron pocket, recording his offenses: seven marks by November.

She sat on the porch steps, staring at the penciled lines. The disciple asked how many times a brother must be forgiven: seven times? The Lord answered: seventy times seven.[8]

Nora tore the page out of her notebook. She struck a match and watched the gray paper curl into black ash in the stone colander. She chose to believe the best of him first, and to hope, and to put up with a good deal.[9]

Mercy, though, possessed edges. When Daniel asked to borrow money for the third time to purchase speculative tooling from a city salesman, Nora looked directly into his eyes and said no, gently. A friend's wounds can be trusted, refusing deceitful kisses.[10] She spoke the truth with calm affection.[11] When Daniel sought pastoral counseling for his old anxieties, she cheered. Mercy with truth makes a person honest, which is the kinder thing.

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[8] Matthew 18:21-22

[9] 1 Corinthians 13:7

[10] Proverbs 27:6

[11] Ephesians 4:15

Open Hands

By the hearth on a cold January evening, Daniel sat on the woven rug beside Nora's rocking chair. Outside the storm windows, winter snow banked high against the cedar siding. The machine shop was quiet for the weekend, its iron lathes cold beneath canvas tarpaulins.

Daniel spoke aloud the fear that had tightened his chest all week: that the municipal contract would fall through, that his hands grew stiff in the winter damp, that his daughter Maddie would face another round of therapy without enough savings in the bank.

Nora set her needlework in her basket. She placed her fingers through his hair and held him steadily while the embers shifted in the grate. She offered no frantic formulas. She drew up no five point recovery plans.

"In the old days, Daniel, you would have paced the floor until dawn, trying to force tomorrow to obey you," she whispered.

"I tried to manage every outcome," Daniel murmured. "I thought love meant holding the wheel so hard my knuckles turned white."

"Love is attention held with open hands,[12]" she said softly. "You set the whole weight down on someone larger than yourself.[13] You let your conduct answer over years whether you are a blessing or a burden.[14] We release the outcome to God. In the center of the house, inside the smallest ring, the light is clear, and peace fills the room.[15]"

Begin small.[16] Choose one person. Put the phone away. Learn one new thing about their week. Write it down. Re-

[12] 1 Corinthians 13:4-7

[13] 1 Peter 5:7; 2 Corinthians 12:9-10

[14] Matthew 7:16-20

[15] 1 John 4:18

[16] Psalm 139:1-2

member it on Friday. Forgive one small thing. Then rest with open hands. Take your time. There is enough of it.[17]

[17] Psalm 46:10; Matthew 6:34